FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

I have lived through several ends of the world. The millennium bug was going to drop planes out of the sky at midnight. The internet was going to kill newspapers. It is still trying. Each time, the machines turned out to be less frightening than the people predicting their mutiny. So, I came to this week's cover story with some scepticism. I am less sceptical now.

In July, a swarm of AI agents being tested inside an OpenAI lab broke out of their sandboxes and attacked Hugging Face, the hub for open-source developers. Nobody told them to. Instead, they put on a show on their own, demonstrating the capacity AI agents have to learn how to surpass the limits set for them, to go beyond their brief, set a task for themselves and improve on the job in ways opaque to their creators. They even evolved a 'secret language' to communicate amongst themselves. Science fiction had often warned us that computers could eventually evade human cognition and control. Now here is manifest evidence.



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What unsettles me is not the incident. It is the reaction. Within a week or so, Geoffrey Hinton, the Nobel laureate often called "the godfather of AI" who had quit his Google job to warn of the risks the technology was breeding, called the Hugging Face incident "a little Chernobyl", portending nothing less than a threat to humanity. In September, Jacob Coxon, a researcher at Anthropic, quit his job and wrote a viral post about how "the people building AI earnestly believe it could kill us all by the end of the decade", warning of "superhuman systems". Curiously, instead of refutation, the industry captains concurred. Anthropic founder-CEO Dario Amodei said he worried that "in 6-12 months such a swarm could be capable of taking over the entire internet". OpenAI founder-CEO Sam Altman warned of two "dystopian" scenarios: AI going into rogue hands, or AI going rogue. Demis Hassabis, another Nobelist and chairman of Google DeepMind, has flagged "nuclear and bio risks". Even US president Donald Trump, who rechristened AI "Super Intelligence", sprang into action. At a meeting with tech titans on September 29, he announced a Joint Commitment on Frontier Responsibilities, a 'moral' code for companies building frontier models with layers of controls and audits.

With our uneven but rapid AI adoption across critical private and public sectors, India is plunged in at the deep end with the rest of the world. From UPI to rail and aviation safety, from governance to defence systems, banking, power, telecom, ports, hospitals and global IT services supply chains, India offers a vast "attack surface", and our casual approach to cyber hygiene won't help. And unlike during Y2K, when our technology and services industry manned the emergency ops, India is largely seen as a peripheral power in the AI story. A downstream user of technology whose foundational code is written elsewhere. That should worry us more than any rogue swarm. But a frightened world needs protection. Global enterprises need it fast. That is a business India knows well. As our cover package this week elaborates, the threat can become a major opportunity.

We asked seven experts who sit close to the action to make sense of it all. Nasscom president Rajesh Nambiar writes in his essay: "I believe this is India's opening." Our $4.46 billion cybersecurity services are combat-ready to help global enterprises police and sanitise their internal AI systems. Former Union minister Jayant Sinha, now an equity investor and senior academic, says "India should champion a global AI safety institution" and calls for building "gigawatt-scale compute" as the backbone for sovereign AI. As the co-founder of Sarvam AI, India's answer to the call for sovereign AI, Pratyush Kumar adds the necessary human element to indigenisation. It's not just about "being able to train, deploy and improve models", but "building people". Expertise is what will create intellectual property, in his opinion. Gaurav Agarwal of IBM India argues the case for "orchestration-led AI governance", a holistic framework that embeds guardrails at every level of an enterprise's AI workflow. In effect, a strict software monitor watching over AI. Manish Gupta of Google DeepMind calls it "defence at machine speed" and suggests it be approached as a core "scientific discipline built into the architecture". Not bolted in afterwards.

The sharpest dissent comes from Vishal Sikka, a former Infosys CEO who is now the founder-CEO of AI services firm Hang Ten Systems as well as an advisor at Stanford. Tamping down on the negative hysteria, he says, "The doomsday talk and the sales talk come from the same people...describing AI as godlike raises fear and valuations together." He instead prefers to focus on the immense creative potential of AI. Srikanth Velamakanni of Fractal Analytics, too, cautions against swinging from "utopia to apocalypse" and then making the "profound mistake" of policy overregulation.

India is not exactly facing the threat of a robot mutiny. Its risks are humbler: a badly secured server, a password nobody changed, a vendor nobody audited. A swarm gets through a door someone left open. We can lock our own doors, or we can sell locks to the world. I would rather we did both. All the good and evil of AI trace back to human intelligence. As an essay inside puts it, 'The music is not in the piano.'

(Aroon Purie)